COUNTRY REPORTS: CAPE VERDE

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Status report

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Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The strategic bases of the successor agenda are set: the Council of Ministers approved Resolução 72/2026 establishing the strategic bases of an Agenda Digital de Cabo Verde 2035, organised in eight strategic axes and monitored by the Observatório da Sociedade da Informação (May 2026), after the Plano de Ação da Estratégia para a Governação Digital 2021–2025 ran out of horizon at the end of 2025. The minister for the economy and digital transition then convened a Consulta Estratégica in Praia on 6 August 2026 to build a national diagnosis and set priorities for the digital-transformation agenda, spanning interoperability, service simplification, digital skills, inclusion, data protection and cybersecurity.

Delivery is owned in several places at once, which the government itself has begun to treat as the problem. Terms of reference published in December 2025 for a National Governance Framework for Digital Transformation record continuing fragmentation and silos across ministry-run portals, and name the Ministry of Finance's special projects unit, UGPE, as implementer of the World Bank-financed Digital Cabo Verde Project and fiduciary overseer of the work. Steering sits with the Conselho Consultivo da Economia Digital, chaired by Vice-Prime Minister Olavo Correia with Secretary of State Pedro Lopes, which held its third ordinary meeting on 25 November 2025 and took the Estratégia da Economia Digital and the Projeto de Inovação Morabeza. The digital ministry's own budget vote, meanwhile, has been cut in each of the last two budget laws.

The gap between committing and delivering is visible on the record. In the 2024 budget debate the Prime Minister committed the Praia and São Vicente technology parks to completion during 2024, the Zona Económica Especial para a Tecnologia to becoming operational, and a budget allocation to create a Fundação para a Ciência, Inovação e Tecnologia.

The Praia technology park opened roughly a year later than the completion date the government had set for it in that debate.

On data the sequencing has run backwards: an autonomous government body for data governance is established, but no data governance strategy or policy stands behind it (2025). Work on a first National Data Strategy was launched at a National Statistics Council conference in April 2025, and a public-administration data strategy and a national artificial-intelligence strategy had been launched by May 2026, with European Union representatives at the kick-off.

Legislation and regulation

A dedicated regulatory framework for satellite communications is only now in draft: the regulator ARME opened a public consultation in August 2026, with submissions accepted to 31 August 2026, on a regime covering licensing, radio-spectrum use, frequency coordination, user protection, network security and emergency communications.

Recent binding law has been made on procurement and on the machinery of service delivery. Use of the eCOMPRAS.cv electronic procurement platform is mandatory for 2026 under article 2 of Decreto-Lei 1/2026, and the government redefined the platform's requirements in 2025 to extend it from central government to local administration and to autonomous services and funds. The Portal de Justiça was created by Decreto-Lei 53/2024 of 4 November, made under Decreto-Legislativo 5/2020 — a public service stood up by legal instrument rather than by project announcement. Lei 38/X/2024 set the regime for electronic processing of court cases, and Decreto-Lei 3/2025 made enrolment in the single social registry the condition for non-contributory benefits and the social pension. The identity estate rests on a similar footing, in Law 43/VIII/2013, Decree-Law 19/2014 and Decree 27/2023, and online transactions on the 2024 e-commerce and digital services law; Decree-Law 9/2021 carries the cybersecurity regime and its incident-reporting duty.

Communications privacy has an unusually firm base. Article 44 of the Constitution makes communications inviolable, restrictable only by law and only ever by judicial decision, and under the Código de Processo Penal interception may be authorised only during the criminal-instruction phase, on application by the Ministério Público and by reasoned order of the juiz de instrução criminal, confined to a catalogue of crimes carrying more than three years' imprisonment and to a maximum of three months, renewable on justification.

The holes sit where the statute book has not caught up with the state's own ambitions. The data-protection statute dates from 2001 and has been amended twice, and the new legal frameworks for digital services, e-commerce and digital banking named in the National 5G Strategy (September 2025) sit at the level of intention rather than statute.

Data protection

Cabo Verde's data-protection authority is funded not through any ministerial vote but through the National Assembly's own Orçamento Privativo, which appropriated CVE 36,313,115 to it for FY2025 under Resolução n.º 160/X/2024, with no own-source revenue — the whole supervisory budget for a regime that reaches every processor of personal data in the country.

The FY2025 appropriation rose about 3.0% on the FY2024 figure, and the authority's whole annual budget is equivalent to about a dozen of the maximum fines the law empowers it to levy.

The law itself is strong. Law 133/V/2001, as amended by Law 41/VIII/2013 and Law 121/IX/2021, is a comprehensive GDPR-style framework covering all personal data, including financial and credit data, providing data-subject rights, special categories and data-protection impact assessments, and it establishes the Comissão Nacional de Protecção de Dados as an independent supervisory authority with power to fine between CVE 50,000 and CVE 3,000,000, alongside criminal penalties of up to two years' imprisonment. Breaches posing a risk to data subjects must be notified within 72 hours, international transfers are regulated with extraterritorial reach over processing connected to the country, and, in the provision that matters most in a joined-up state, interconnecting personal data across systems requires the authority's prior authorisation (2025); around 62 public and private institutions consume shared identity data under institutional protocols (2025).

What cannot be seen is the enforcement. The authority completed a decade of operation in 2025 and has taken synthetic-media harms into its casework, but the country publishes neither complaints and feedback on data protection and privacy, nor the authority's performance and results (2025). The next test is already on the table: the

Judicial Police is seeking inter-institutional access to the national video-surveillance system for criminal investigation, a request backed by the Minister of Justice (May 2026). Against that, the country's Digital Freedom score of 83.7 of 100 in 2023, seventh of 54 African states, has fallen 7.7 points over 2014–2023, while protection against discrimination rose 38.9 points over the same decade to 75.0 and first place on the continent.

Regional collaboration

The African instrument is bound by an act of the National Assembly: Resolucao 153/IX/2020, gazetted on 17 March 2020, approves accession to the African Union Convention on Cyber Security and Personal Data Protection and publishes the Convention's full Portuguese text. The data protection authority also says it promoted accession to the Council of Europe's Convention 108 alongside the African one (2025).

Its ECOWAS obligations are the denser layer. Ministers meeting at Cotonou on 4 October 2024 adopted the ECOWAS Digital Sector Development Strategy 2024–2029 and urged member states to work towards full implementation of the Roaming Regulation by all mobile operators by the end of 2025. Yet in the Community MTEF Budget 2026–2028 the Youth Entrepreneurship in ICT programme line records nil from 2024 through the 2028 estimates, against a Community Levy of UA 195,850,000 in 2026.

The regional identity area it sits in has also narrowed. Burkina Faso, Mali and Niger severed ties with ECOWAS in 2024 and are rolling out an Alliance of Sahel States biometric identity card of their own; the ECOWAS–World Bank WURI programme's second Supervisory Committee validated a cross-border ID interoperability strategy and reviewed a 2026 regional work plan in March 2026.

The Lusophone channel is where Cabo Verde speaks in its own voice: it presented its e-government and systems modernisation progress to the CPLP's third interministerial meeting on electronic governance, in Lisbon on 25 March 2025, and joined a PALOP exchange on digital identity and public services in March 2026. Reaching outward, NOSi provides data-centre hosting to other African countries and signed a memorandum with Angola's SETIC FP in March 2026. Two dependencies ran the other way, and one has closed: the identity credentials were produced and personalised under contract by Portugal's Imprensa Nacional Casa da Moeda (July 2025) until national production began on 18 May 2026, while the country is still not a participant in the Pan-African Payment and Settlement System in any category (June 2026).

Standards

Cabo Verde has no data quality framework for its government information systems and no open source software policy or action plan for the public sector (2025) — the two places where a common rule would bind what gets built. What is standardised is operational and financial rather than architectural: a system monitors the uptime of government information systems and guidance exists for replacing legacy ones, and a unified budget classification and chart of accounts is in use across both central and sub-national government.

The published-standards record is strongest where money moves. SISP, which operates the card and interbank payment infrastructure, holds PCI-DSS and ISO 27001 certifications and publishes audited annual accounts (2023), and the central bank runs the clearing and settlement layer applying the BIS principles for financial market infrastructures (2025). Procurement is the other bright spot: e-procurement data is published in line with the Open Contracting Data Standard (2025), and the platform contract itself sets sovereignty terms — perpetual licensing, unlimited users, deployment on national infrastructure, and full control of the source code and the application generator with complete transfer of knowledge and technology.

Interoperability, the standard that would matter most to a state whose systems all draw on one identity register, is still being paid to be built: a 2025 World Bank additional financing package funds the strengthening of the interoperability framework and the government digital business architecture, PDEX, building on a service-prioritisation roadmap and a blueprint for the existing digital public infrastructure drawn up under the parent project, with the closing date extended to 2028. One naming layer has come home: ARME launched a national .cv domain management system on 31 May 2024, with the registrar company OLACV taking over all registration requests.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

Media freedom fell 14.8 points over 2014–2023, its fourth most deteriorated governance indicator of the decade, and civic checks and balances fell 22.1 points to 49.7 of 100 — in a country that still ranks first in Africa for freedom of expression and belief, at 97.3 of 100 in 2023 and fourth for media freedom. Accountability and transparency is now one of the country's three weakest sub-categories, at 56.0 of 100 and ninth of 54, its 6.0-point fall the second largest of any of the sixteen. The scrutiny layer is eroding inside an otherwise strong governance record.

The consultation machinery exists and is one-directional. There are platforms for citizens to submit complaints, compliments, suggestions and information requests, with published service standards, and national platforms for citizens and businesses to take part in policy decision-making, including anonymous feedback, though petitions cannot be submitted through them; users were involved in designing the public service portal, the tax online services and social insurance and pensions, but not the job portal (2025). What is missing is the return leg: government responses on those platforms are not publicly available, and the government does not show how it has updated services in response to feedback. The index agrees: deliberative and participatory governance scores 64.0 of 100 and 17th of 54, down 8.9 points over the decade, the country's weakest rank inside a Participation sub-category that is second on the continent.

On records the two halves have moved in opposite directions: what a requester can reach has improved over the decade while what the state discloses of its own motion has gone backwards, against a government transparency portal put to public consultation in mid-2025 and launched in January 2026, and an Open Government Partnership commitment to a national open data portal. The sharpest argument is over official statistics: in late July 2026 the Prime Minister told Parliament that INE had produced falsified data, and announced an independent evaluation of the institute, whose Conselho Directivo rejected the allegations categorically on 3 August 2026 and offered to host any external evaluation mission or peer review.

Finance

Financial sustainability

Cabo Verde's 2026 budget law carries no loan money for its digital-platform programme, after loan money of CVE 216.8m in 2025, the World Bank's Digital Cabo Verde loan and CVE 1.24bn in 2024; the World Bank project itself runs to 2028.

At the appropriated stage the state's own money made up 98.3% of the digital lines read in the 2026 budget, against 96.0% in 2025 and 61.1% in 2024, the lines counted including programmes only partly digital.

Much of what keeps systems running is paid for by charging. Ministries buy services from the state IT enterprise NOSi under protocols budgeted at CVE 333.3m for 2026; in 2024 those protocols brought NOSi CVE 456m, and its service revenue reached CVE 1.0bn, 98.4% of plan. Decreto-Lei 36/2026 of 21 May 2026 sets the fees for digital public services delivered through the Portal Único, with a 10% reduction for services completed online. In the 2026

law passport, residence-card and registry fees make up CVE 306.5m of the CVE 333.9m budget of the justice modernisation institute IMIJ, and the universal-service fund FUSI is budgeted at CVE 122.1m, as in each of the two previous years.

One new domestic line has appeared: the 2026 law opens the first dedicated cybersecurity budget unit, at CVE 20m. What is voted is only partly spent: the digital-platform programme executed 64.9% of its CVE 568.2m domestic budget in 2024.

MoUs and other agreements

Cabo Verde's technology diplomacy runs on cooperation instruments rather than contracts. NOSi signed a memorandum of understanding with Angola's SETIC FP in March 2026 covering cybersecurity, data-centre management, audit and customer service; Nigeria and Cabo Verde launched an African Digital Corridor in September 2025 to cooperate on technology and trade; and the government designated Olavo Correia as Tech Ambassador and signed a membership protocol with the Tech Diplomacy Global Institute in March 2026. The working relationships sit a level below them, in the public-private partnership arrangements used to deliver government services online (2025).

New investments

Four consecutive African Development Bank budget support operations since 2021, worth about USD 88 million, make e-governance and public financial management reform Cabo Verde's most sustained line of external digital finance. There are 20 costed commitments, announced between 2017 and 2026, running to 2028 and worth about USD 336 million converted; six of them and about USD 131 million are the Bank's, ahead of the World Bank's five worth about USD 89 million, the European Investment Bank's two worth about USD 65 million and five from Chinese state institutions worth about USD 48 million, with Japan and the Global Partnership for Education making up the rest. E-government and public administration took about USD 129 million of it, connectivity about USD 91 million, the ICT industry about USD 58 million, energy about USD 29 million, sectoral information systems about USD 18 million and cybersecurity about USD 11 million; none went to digital identity, data storage or statistics. The largest live commitment is the European Investment Bank's regional digital connectivity loan.

That EUR 37 million framework loan (2024, about USD 40 million) pays for a branch off a new Europe-to-South Africa submarine cable, modernisation of the national transmission network and an upgrade of Cabo Verde Telecom's systems, after EUR 22 million to the same operator to 2022. The African Development Bank signed a EUR 17.7 million financing agreement on 31 December 2025 for a second phase of the electronic governance and public financial management reform programme, which it prices at USD 20.63 million (December 2025). Before it: EUR 20 million for e-governance and public administration in 2021-2022, the same again to 2025, SDR 15.72 million for the first public financial management phase (2024-2025), SDR 11.94 million for the Technology Park (2022-2027) and EUR 24 million of results-based financing for the Morabeza Innovation Project from 2024, initial money against a EUR 156 million programme that remains open to other international partners (November 2025).

The World Bank's USD 20 million Digital Cabo Verde project (November 2020) runs to 2028 with a further USD 20 million proposed in May 2025, and both are now spending: at the Bank's September 2026 review the original financing stood about 80% executed and the additional financing for 2025 to 2028 about 40%, with school connectivity named its priority. Chinese money is older: an RMB 84.5 million China Eximbank loan signed in February 2017 at 2% over 20 years, financing a Huawei contract for the E-Governance Project, and a USD 5 million Ministry of Commerce grant for the Network Access Support Project, handed over in January 2020.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

The regulator's first-quarter 2026 count puts active SIM cards at 588,603, a penetration of 113.9 per cent and 0.8 per cent down on the quarter, and internet subscriptions at 511,702, up 1 per cent on the quarter and down 4 per cent on the year as mobile broadband subscriptions fell 16.4 per cent and fixed broadband rose 12.9 per cent. The internet subscriber base had contracted during 2025 while the mobile base grew by about one per cent, the great majority of mobile connections were broadband-capable (2025), and 73.5 per cent of individuals used the internet in 2023, with penetration still around three-quarters of the population at the end of 2025.

Starlink went live in December 2024, well before a dedicated satellite framework reached consultation, and held 0.64 per cent of internet subscriptions at the end of March 2026, up 0.20 points on the quarter, against 72 per cent for CVTelecom and 27.3 per cent for Unitel T+ — a thin return on the Prime Minister's expectation, put to the 2025 budget debate, that its arrival would shift competition in telecoms. The regulator ARME has since opened a public consultation on a satellite-communications framework, with submissions to 31 August 2026.

The state extended a €37 million sovereign guarantee to the incumbent CV Telecom in April 2026 for telecommunications infrastructure, including an inter-island submarine cable, and within a fortnight the competitor UNITEL T+ objected, demanding network neutrality, fair competition and open-access separation of infrastructure from services. Domestic redistribution runs through FUSI, the universal-service fund financed by operator contributions and the radio-spectrum fee.

The plumbing underneath is thin: one exchange point, CV-IXP in Praia, with five peers, six connections and 23 Gbps of connected capacity in 2024. The .cv domain moved onto a localised management system in May 2024, launched by ARME with the registrar company OLACV taking over all registration requests. On the Ibrahim Index, Internet and Computers rose 21.1 points over 2014-2023 to 60.7 of 100, 10th of 54 African states, even as Infrastructure was its lowest-ranked sub-category of the sixteen at 56.2, 13th of 54 in 2023. The National 5G Strategy targets 90 per cent internet penetration by 2026 and regional digital hub status by 2030.

That 2026 penetration target sits well above where penetration actually stood at the end of 2025, and is out of reach on the current trajectory.

The national operator and an internet exchange operator signed a non-binding letter of intent, announced 29 September 2026, under which the operator would provide transport capacity between Lisbon and Sao Paulo in exchange for access to the exchange's services in five cities; a definitive agreement is still to come.

Data Storage

Cabo Verde's government data-centre estate is state-owned and public-private: the African Development Bank's Technology Park Phase II appraisal documents three facilities — a government-owned DC1 in Praia financed by Portugal, a DC2 in Praia financed under Phase I and run as a PPP concession, and a government-run disaster-recovery DC3 under Phase II, with Tier III data centres among the phase's outputs. The park was inaugurated in May 2025, with a second campus at Mindelo on São Vicente, data centre included, inaugurated the same month.

Government computing sits on a single shared cloud platform open to all government entities — private, government-run, and providing infrastructure as a service, under a hosting policy of keeping government data inside the country. Under the data-protection law, cross-border transfers of personal data turn on the recipient country's adequacy, as defined by the data protection authority, or on the data subject's consent.

What the state does not do is measure any of it. Cabo Verde neither monitors nor publishes usage, security and savings on its government cloud, nor usage, compliance and benefits of its interoperability framework (2025). The next layer is still on paper: a blockchain-based interoperable cloud platform for government was put out to tender by NOSi on terms of reference of July 2023.

There is no commercial alternative within reach — the nearest hyperscale cloud regions are in southern Africa — and the government frames the point as sovereignty, the minister presenting its 5G strategy naming submarine cables, data centres and the technology park as central elements of the country's digital sovereignty.

Energy

Firms reported an average of 0.8 electrical outages a month, about ten a year, in the World Bank's 2024 Enterprise Survey — on a grid that reached 98.6 per cent of the population in 2023, with a rural-urban gap under three percentage points: 96.9 per cent of the rural population against about 99.4 per cent of the urban (2023). Access to Energy is the country's strongest infrastructure measure in the 2024 Ibrahim Index at 89.2 of 100 in 2023, 8th of 54 African states after a ten-year gain of 9.7 points.

Generation is the weaker half of the account. Renewables supplied 18.27 per cent of electricity output in 2021 on an archipelago with no fuel of its own. Four micro-grid contracts were signed in April 2025 to serve isolated communities on Santo Antão, São Nicolau and Fogo.

Technical Capacity

Effective Administration scored 68.9 of 100 in 2023, 11th of 54 African states, and moved 0.2 points across the whole decade to 2023: a capable administration that is not becoming more so.

The state builds rather than buys. NOSi, a state public enterprise, develops and maintains more than 100 e-government solutions, the SNIAC civil identification system among them, and exports digital solutions to the wider African region. Where that model has failed, the government has said so itself, recording that attempts between 2008 and 2015 to build e-procurement capability in-house were discontinued for technical inadequacy, high cost and maintenance difficulty, and that heavily customised, vendor-dependent solutions created continuity risk. The public-finance platform has faltered too: in October 2024 the finance ministry announced a week of instability in SIGOF, which runs the budget cycle through to payment of suppliers and staff, and warned that state payments could be delayed.

The pipeline behind the institutions runs through the public university: the Universidade de Cabo Verde teaches a four-year degree in informatics and computer engineering in Praia.

Cybersecurity

Cabo Verde stood up its national cyber-defence machinery on 30 October 2025, launching a Security Operations Centre and a Computer Security Incident Response Team inside the state's private technological network to monitor, prevent and respond to cyber incidents. Both were built by NOSi, the state's IT agency, with World Bank support. The duty they backstop is older: Decree-Law 9/2021 requires entities to report significant cybersecurity incidents to the National Cybersecurity Centre, and the country sat in Tier 4 of the ITU Global Cybersecurity Index 2024, scoring 17.36 of 20 on its regulatory pillar.

Governance of the systems themselves is where it thins. Formal arrangements for system operations — compliance, security and audit trails — are not in place for the customs, tax, HR, payroll, e-procurement or treasury single-account systems; only the financial management system has them, and its governance reporting is internal and unpublished (2025).

The estate's exposure showed on election night. After the 2026 legislative elections the president of NOSi apologised over the disruption to the broadcast of results, put at the time to a cyber-attack; a week later the agency had published no conclusions, and its preliminary report, two days after that, pointed instead to causes of a technical order.

Away from the state estate, the Judicial Police's cybercrime brigade warned in February 2025 of fraud schemes built on impersonation and bogus loan offers, and on third-party bank accounts used as bridges for fraudulent funds, with impersonation of public figures a recurring pattern and users' digital literacy named as the cornerstone of prevention. The same force is now seeking inter-institutional access to the national video-surveillance system for criminal investigation, with the Minister of Justice behind it (May 2026).

DPI

Data Exchange

About 62 public and private institutions were connected to the national identification registry and SNIAC by 2025, consuming shared citizen data under institutional protocols. The route is PDEX, the Platform for Data Exchange, built and operated by NOSi since 2018 as the country's interoperability service bus and used by central and local government alike, and the consular portal's integrations with the civil identification system all run through it. The core systems of the state — financial management, debt and public investment, tax, customs, human resources and social insurance, and e-procurement — exchange data both point to point and through a government service bus (2025).

What has not joined that layer is the more telling list. The tax administration's connection is a roadmap rather than a system: a 2023 assignment for the revenue directorate sets out converging its internal tax and customs systems and connecting them to external commercial, land, vehicle, financial and social security registers. A 2024 tender to modernise property registration and construction and environmental licensing requires the new modules to reach other systems through PDEX. The Cadastro Social Único was designed to determine potential eligibility for social programmes partly from data exchanged with other administrative systems (2018). Even for the company-registration platform, the integrations with the tax authority, social security, the labour inspectorate and the gazette, and the PDEX services behind them, were put out to a technical-assistance tender.

The clearest new flow is in justice: the criminal-process system of the Sistema de Informação da Justiça, handed over in March 2026, wires National Police stations and Judicial Police delegations directly to the courts and gives every case a unique number. The diaspora electoral registration project consumes SNIAC APIs into the electoral register (2024), while automatic voter registration, which would need the electoral process fully integrated with SNIAC, was still under deliberation (2024).

The government publishes nothing on the usage, compliance or benefits of its interoperability framework (2025). A 2025 World Bank additional financing package funds strengthening of PDEX, running to a 2028 closing date.

Digital Identity and CRVS

SNIAC had issued about 631,720 national identity cards, 513,862 electronic passports and 1,291,910 authentication and qualified-signature certificates since its launch, and served more than 30 million requests through over 134 configured services (January 2026). Those are issuance totals, not holders: the government's reference pages for SNIAC and Autentika carry no activation figure for the mobile digital key and no coverage rate (July 2026). The card itself is compulsory from the age of four for every citizen, resident or diaspora, issued since January 2018, and costs 14 euro on a normal online order through the consular portal, with exemptions for children aged four to seven and for citizens over 60 without income.

It was built as a token as well as a document: a polycarbonate electronic card whose chip carries a digital certificate alongside identification, authentication and digital-signature applications. Using those functions requires a smart-card reader, dedicated middleware and a PIN letter obtained from the issuing service. The Chave Móvel Digital de Cabo Verde, created by Decreto-Legislativo 5/2020 with implementing rules in Portaria 27/2022, provides online authentication and digital signature, and is used with the card for single sign-on across government portals.

Behind the credential sits SNIAC, created by Law 43/VIII/2013 as a centralised platform capturing biographic and biometric data at the point of registration, with the conservatórias as collection points and mobile units for citizens who cannot travel; records have been digitised since 2001 and the central citizen database has run since 2009. Every child is issued a unique identification number at birth. Foreign residents can attach the mobile key to their residence permit. The credentials were produced and personalised abroad, under contract with Portugal's Imprensa Nacional Casa da Moeda — an authorisation of more than CVE 176 million that the Council of Ministers granted in July 2025 after the services had already been rendered — until the national printer began producing them at home on 18 May 2026.

The identity-document earmark has not moved by a single escudo across three consecutive budgets, standing at CVE 306,516,802 from the FY2024 annex through the enacted FY2025 and FY2026 laws — a ceiling rolled forward rather than re-estimated.

Digital Payments and Fintech

Cabo Verde is not a participant in the Pan-African Payment and Settlement System in any category (June 2026). The domestic plumbing is older and better settled: the central bank operates the SGDL and SIGMA systems and manages SICIL, the interbank clearing and settlement system operated by SISP, applying the BIS principles for financial market infrastructures, and the payment system is governed by three 2018 instruments on system regulation, on payment services and electronic money, and on licensing. Government payments run over both a real-time gross settlement system and a fast payment system or automated clearing house (2025).

The central bank is SISP's largest shareholder and chairs its board, so it both regulates and part-owns the operator of the country's card and interbank infrastructure; SISP publishes audited accounts and holds PCI-DSS and ISO 27001 certification (2023). An instant payment system was announced for the first quarter of 2026 (December 2025).

For households the digital channels are real but narrow. A-Pay, certified by SISP, takes municipal taxes and fees, utility bills and insurance without a trip to a Post Office counter (2024), and person-to-person transfers run through mobile money applications such as Makeba, partnered with a local bank, using QR codes, NFC or a personal transaction code (2025). Take-up splits on the familiar lines: 33.3 per cent of adults personally held a mobile-money account in 2024, 38.1 per cent in towns against 19.9 per cent in rural areas and 38.0 per cent of men against 29.2 per cent of women. Social transfers were designed for digital payment: the Rendimento Social de Inclusão was to be paid monthly by electronic transfer from the Treasury into beneficiaries' bank accounts (2018). On the revenue side, periodic withholding declarations must be filed electronically by entities keeping organised accounts and by micro and small firms, through a credentialed portal such as Porton di Nos Ilhas (2026). The 2024 e-commerce law obliges merchants to offer authorised payment methods and disclose the providers they use, and places liability for failed execution on the payment service provider. Access to banking services remains one of the country's ten worst-scoring governance measures, at 40.2 of 100 (2023).

Registries

Cabo Verde's digital land register runs on Sal, Boavista, Maio and the rural area of São Vicente (2022), under the Regime Jurídico do Cadastro Predial, first published in 2009, amended in 2014 and reformed again in March 2024, which gives every cadastred property a unique identification number.

Civil registration is the opposite case. Birth registration stands at roughly 99 per cent, driven by the link between the civil register and the identity system (2026); the country takes a maximum 100.0 on the 2024 Ibrahim Index measure of civil registration, first of 54 African states and unchanged over the decade; and a WHO-supported assessment in April 2025 found almost all deaths certified by a doctor while recommending real-time digitisation of notifications. Births, marriages, deaths and stillbirths are recorded in a data stream connecting the civil registries to SNIAC and other government systems (2025).

The social registry is the most complete of the rest: the Cadastro Social Único is treated as the single gateway to all social benefits and held data on over 91,164 households, 64 per cent of the population, in February 2026. The tax authority is under a statutory duty to keep an up-to-date central register of taxpayers covering both individuals and businesses, an instrument published in August 2025 creates a computerised national register of traffic offences with a penalty points system, and company procedures moved online on the Empresa Online platform, in beta with a pilot group of users (March 2026), where forming, amending or dissolving a company is free for three months after launch and then costs CVE 10,000 an act, paid only electronically (April 2026).

The electoral register is the outlier. It has been a centralised digital database since the late 2000s, capturing fingerprints, facial images and signatures across successive electoral cycles, but the National Elections Commission says its management system and rolls are out of date, and has asked the government for a new database for 2026, through automatic registration or a fresh base registration (December 2024). At no published grain does the FY2024 budget carry a line for a civil register, biometric enrolment, an interoperability layer, a service bus or a single window.

Sectoral management information systems

Criminal case processing has gone digital across the whole court system: the justice institute's second evaluation of the Justice Information System counts 46,000 criminal case files handled digitally across all 17 comarcas in the 2025/2026 judicial year, through the system's integration with National Police and Judicial Police stations, with 401 justice professionals signing with qualified digital signatures (September 2026). The case module has run since January 2025 and by March 2026 was operating in every judicial district, giving each case a unique number, and the civil-process component waits on authorisation for three pilots.

Health is the laggard. The single digital patient record application, M1, was in use only in health facilities in Praia, while DHIS2 ran in every national health service structure for aggregated data and all public health programmes (2023). A national health information system lets services share clinical and administrative information through a centralised repository, alongside a public health observatory run with the statistics and public health institutes, and 24 telemedicine units were handed over as the health ministry announced a unique patient code, a digital clinical history and electronic prescription (December 2025). The medicines circuit is now tracked in real time nationally, the system integrated with customs to detect illegal imports (July 2026).

Education is further along. SIGE reached all 395 basic education schools by February 2019, after covering all 43 secondary schools the year before, recording attendance, grades and administrative data with a parent-facing student file; SIGAE tracks scholarship vacancies, financial management and scholarship recipients at home and in the diaspora (2025).

On the fiscal side the customs and tax administrations are merged, running a commercial off-the-shelf customs system and a custom-built tax system (2025), and electronic invoicing has been mandatory for all companies since June 2022, electronic filing of individual income tax returns since 2015. Human resources run on a custom system with an employee and manager self-service portal, with payroll built on and linked to it, and the pension system doubles as the public sector's.

What these systems mostly lack is governance: compliance, security and audit-trail arrangements are not in place for the customs, tax, HR, payroll, e-procurement or treasury systems, and only the financial management system has them, reporting internally (2025). Both of the country's public financial management scores in the 2024 Ibrahim Index weakened over the preceding decade.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

The vote for Cabo Verde's digital ministry has fallen 87.5 per cent across two budgets, from CVE 1,390,965,632 in FY2024 to CVE 369,781,930 and then CVE 174,200,533 in FY2026, while total state expenditure rose 11.3 per cent — 0.18 per cent of state spending against 1.62 per cent two years earlier, with capital appropriated at a printed zero for a second consecutive year. The ministry executed 33.0 per cent of its reprogrammed FY2024 budget against a state-wide 76.5, more than forty points below Finance, the Presidency and the Court of Auditors, and 37.9 per cent in FY2025 against 79.1. By the first quarter of 2026 its reprogrammed budget stood at 9.3 times its appropriation, and CVE 1.45 billion of loan financing had been moved into the Plataforma Digital e da Inovação programme alone — nearly three times its whole voted total — against a budget law showing zero external borrowing for it.

The digital capital budget is re-created every year and never spent: CVE 553,090,000 appropriated in FY2024 and a printed literal zero executed; nothing appropriated in FY2025, CVE 661,584,487 created in-year by virement, and 1.3 per cent of it spent.

The public counter has nonetheless been rebuilt. Gov.cv launched in February 2026 as a web and app gateway to identity, tax, education, transport and social services. The Portal de Justiça has since December 2024 issued civil-registry, land, commercial, vehicle and criminal-record certificates and handled identity card renewal online, and a fully online company creation portal opened in March 2026, to a pilot group of users rather than the general public.

After in-house attempts between 2008 and 2015 involving NOSi and Oracle solutions were discontinued for technical inadequacy, cost and maintenance difficulty, the national e-procurement platform has been re-let to ACIN-iCloud Solutions for CVE 70,000,000 over four years, which the government converts to EUR 634,834 (March 2026). Cabo Verde publishes neither service delivery performance and user experience nor results and spending on whole-of-government digital transformation, and after the 2026 election-night disruption NOSi's preliminary report pointed to causes of a technical order, with an external forensic audit still under way (May 2026).

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Every Cabo Verdean municipality runs the same core municipal system, but only a handful run the modules that deal with territory: the Municipal Information System (SIM), covering financial management, is operational in all of the country's municipalities, while the property-management module SIM LAND has run since 2017 only in Sal, São Vicente, Maio and Boa Vista, and a World Bank-financed consultancy was tendered to build SIMple territory-management modules for every municipal council (2025).

Otherwise the digital state below the national level consists mostly of national platforms reaching downwards. The public financial management system carries the budgets of both central and local government (2025), and electronic procurement, running centrally since 2020, had its requirements redefined in 2025 to take in local administration alongside autonomous services and funds, and its use is compulsory for state purchasing in 2026. Where a câmara acts on its own account the work is small and local: municipalities are signing protocols with the national Post Office to digitise and standardise street addressing, island by island (2026). The first council portal of its own is on the way: São Vicente's council presented a platform of 17 services, from applications and real-time case tracking to payments and documents with legal validity, for operation by the end of 2026, funded by the UN joint office (August 2026).

The government treats the join as the thing still missing: its stated aim is end-to-end digital public services integrating central government and the municipalities (March 2026).

Rural digital data capture

Digital capture in Cabo Verde is organised island by island, and on most islands it has not happened yet. The one application that records patients digitally was in use only in health facilities in the capital (2023), and the digital land register ran only on Sal, Boavista, Maio and rural São Vicente (2022). Even civil registration, the strongest of the country's registries, was still being advised to digitise notifications in real time (May 2025). What crosses the water is newer: 24 telemedicine units were delivered to the health service (December 2025), and the criminal justice platform has been extended to comarcas across the islands (May 2026).

The rural condition these systems would record has been moving the wrong way for ten years. Rural Representation and Participation is Cabo Verde's most deteriorated governance indicator of the decade, falling 26.5 points over 2014-2023 to 73.5 of 100 and 17th of 54 African states, and Rural Economy is the fastest-declining of the country's sixteen governance sub-categories, down 8.4 points to 73.2 of 100 and 9th of 54 (2023). The material measures beneath it held: Rural Land and Water Access was unchanged at 77.7 of 100 and 6th of 54, and Rural Economy Support rose 1.2 points to 68.3 and 21st of 54 across the same decade. What fell was rural voice, not rural land or money. Rural market access, the fourth of those measures, is among the indicators the index has no data for in Cabo Verde at all.

The agricultural evidence base is being built rather than extended: a sixth general agricultural census was launched (July 2025), and a rural development programme's geographic information system was put out to tender for updating and integration with its monitoring software (February 2026). Power is not the constraint on any of this: rural electrification is close to universal and within a few points of the urban figure (2023).

Technology

AI

Cabo Verde's artificial intelligence policy was still at the drafting stage in 2026: a national artificial intelligence strategy, alongside a data strategy for public administration, was kicked off by May 2026, with European Union representatives at the table. Until then the subject had no agenda of its own — artificial intelligence, robotics, blockchain, 5G and the internet of things are placed inside the digital-governance strategy rather than treated separately (March 2025). Domestic commentary is pressing for a framework law with algorithmic oversight (April 2025), and ECOWAS has set a target of a regional AI governance framework for West Africa that would reach Cabo Verde (January 2026).

Use in running systems is thin and concentrated in justice. The justice institute demonstrated an integrated artificial-intelligence assistant on its portal (October 2025), and 110 judges, prosecutors and court officers had been trained in artificial intelligence by September 2026. NOSi and the domestic firm SINTAXY launched an artificial-intelligence application automating NOSi's own accounting in November 2024, offered for public and private bodies' financial management. The Finance Minister stated that a US$9 million contract for artificial-intelligence-assisted scanning equipment at the national ports is under way (January 2026). The World Bank's GovTech Maturity Index has Cabo Verde using chatbots or AI-enabled discussion forums in its citizen-engagement channels (2025), and NOSi's chief executive has named disruptive innovation, with digital identity and interoperability, as a pillar of the target of at least 60 per cent of vital public services online by 2026 (2024) — a target, not a deployment.

The data protection authority has moved ahead of the policy. It marked its tenth anniversary in March 2025 with a conference attended by the Prime Minister, at which its president argued for dialogue among the bodies that govern data as the way to balance AI regulation, with AI harms and constitutional rights on the agenda; it has handled image-manipulation cases since 2021, two of them generative-AI deepfakes. The national press debates whether artificial intelligence widens the technology gap between rich and poor countries, with the local argument that without national data the country cannot train its own algorithms (May 2025), and the university runs a lecture cycle on artificial intelligence (April 2025). Secretary of State Pedro Lopes led a delegation to Nigeria's Government Leadership and AI Summit in September 2025, part of a pattern of small-state tech diplomacy that also takes in She Code.ai and GITEX.

ICT Industry

The clearest sign of a domestic technology industry in Cabo Verde is not a private firm but the state's own software house: NOSi develops and maintains more than 100 e-government solutions and exports digital solutions to the wider African region (2024). It is also the recruiting pipeline for the foreign firms arriving to sit alongside it — the Portuguese cybersecurity company VisionWare, which has taken space in both of the new technology parks, hires its local staff through NOSi's Akademia (May 2025).

The parks that are meant to house the sector arrived late. In the 2024 budget debate the Prime Minister committed the Praia and São Vicente technology parks to conclusion during 2024, and the Zona Económica Especial para a Tecnologia to becoming operational (November 2023); TechPark CV at Praia was inaugurated in May 2025 with African Development Bank backing. By that inauguration it had drawn in a couple of dozen firms from several countries and created a few hundred jobs (May 2025). A special economic zone for technology is being created alongside the parks as a regulatory sandbox, with reversing brain drain among its stated aims (2025).

The state's stated ambition is an export industry rather than a supplier base for itself. The Prime Minister has positioned Cabo Verde as "uma plataforma de economia digital em África", naming the two parks as the instruments of that position (November 2024), and TechPark CV is pitched as a digital hub for the continent rather than a domestic facility (May 2025). Behind that sits a government policy to support GovTech startups and private-sector investment, with public financing for startups and small firms to innovate (2025), and public support for the digital startup base is being scaled as an explicit growth instrument for a small island economy (July 2025).

Innovation ecosystem

Cabo Verde's innovation sector is measured on what goes into it and barely at all on what comes out of it: the government publishes no results or progress on its public-sector digital skills programme, its public-sector innovation programme or its support for startups and small firms, and the innovation institution's own annual performance reporting stays internal (2025). On the one external ranking, the country placed 90th in WIPO's 2024 Global Innovation Index.

The machinery underneath is real enough. There is a strategy and a programme to improve public sector innovation, with an established government innovation lab leading it and digital skills and public service innovation as its focus (2025), and that work is done with the private sector, including public-private arrangements for delivering government services online. A second TechPark campus at Mindelo on São Vicente, including a data centre, was inaugurated in May 2025, and three Cabo Verdean hubs belong to the AfriLabs network, among them the Maio Business Center and the Business Incubation Center (2025).

What the state does not do is buy from the firms it is trying to create: there is no procurement policy prioritising bids from startups or small firms, such as a quota (2025). The newest instruments steer rather than spend — a one-stop shop for startups announced in March 2026, whose job is to guide founders to finance instruments that already exist rather than to create new ones, and RABIDA, launched in March 2026 to draw the diaspora into the digital economy.

The showcase layer is the busiest part of it. Cabo Verde took its largest-ever delegation, 25 startups, to Web Summit 2025 in Portugal and staged a SikaBaDu summit there to connect the sector with the diaspora (November 2025); the Re!nventa hackathon set young innovators from the country and the diaspora on public-sector challenges (May 2026); and the Digital Awards Cabo Verde announced the finalists of its first edition in January 2025.

Capacity

Literacy

The measure of Cabo Verdean education that fell furthest over the last decade is the one about who gets it: Equality in Education fell 9.0 points over 2014-2023 to 55.3 of 100, 21st of 54 African states, the country's weakest rank on any education indicator (2023). Everything around it sits near the top of the continent. Education as a whole ranked 3rd of 54 African states at 71.1 of 100, Education Quality rose 6.3 points over the same decade to 71.3 of 100, 5th of 54, and teacher supply and qualification scored 97.6 of 100, 3rd of 54, one of the ten best scores Cabo Verde holds on any governance indicator (2023). The same index carries no data at all for education completion, so that part of the sector goes unranked (2023).

Headline literacy is high, and the population it describes is small, mostly urban and largely schooled (2021 census). The divergence is digital, and it is about use rather than reach: connection has run ahead of what the population can do with it (2025), and rural and lower-income households have less dependable devices and access than urban ones, which limits what can be taught remotely even where the school's own records are fully digitised — basic and secondary schools run on the education ministry's integrated school management and student-records systems. The government offers digital skills programmes for citizens and schools, free to use (2025).

Where that literacy is thin it surfaces as loss. The Polícia Judiciária has warned of fraud schemes built on impersonation and bogus loan offers, and on third-party bank accounts used as bridges for fraudulent funds (February 2025), and is investigating an online sexual-extortion scheme run through fake profiles (May 2026). Domestic commentary has argued for putting artificial intelligence into schools alongside training for the teachers (May 2025).

Training and skills

Cabo Verde's newest skills programme trains young people for work that is not in Cabo Verde. Skodji Digital launched in January 2026 to widen young people's access to the global digital economy, and it is aimed at youth unemployment, training young Cabo Verdeans for remote work and digital microenterprises (February 2026) — and for the global gig economy. It sits under a national digital-skills strategy developed with the World Bank through the Digital Cabo Verde programme (August 2025), the same operation that carries the Bank's financing for connectivity, digital government and digital skills to 2028.

In schools the instrument is physical: WebLab digital skills laboratories have been installed in 44 secondary schools (2024), and the programme has reached students in the thousands (October 2024), though the NOSi-run project was suspended in December 2022 and its laboratories in the secondary schools were still locked a year later (November 2023). Above school level, the Universidade de Cabo Verde runs a four-year degree in informatics and computer engineering and a master's in informatics engineering, in its second intake of 18 students (March 2026). Training tied

to a named employer and a named role is visible at the edges: a Portuguese cybersecurity firm established in the TechParks recruits its local staff through the NOSi Akademia pipeline (May 2025), and upskilling counts are reported for TechPark CV itself (May 2025).

The state trains its own staff too, and says least about that. There is both a strategy and a programme to improve digital skills in the public sector, focused on basic digital skills and data literacy (2025). But no results or progress are published for that programme, for the public sector innovation programme, or for support to startups and small firms, and the innovation institution's own performance reporting stays internal (2025). Who has been trained, and toward what role, is the part that does not leave the building.

Research institutions

Public money for research entered the record as a budget line: the 2024 budget package carried a dotação to create a Fundação para a Ciência, Inovação e Tecnologia (November 2023). At the Universidade de Cabo Verde, which teaches informatics and computer engineering, work on the newer subject matter shows up as a lecture cycle on artificial intelligence and computational chemistry (April 2025).

Inclusion

Access to services

Equal access to public services is Cabo Verde's weakest inclusion measure in the 2024 Ibrahim Index, at 42.3 of 100 and 25th of 54 African states in 2023, down 3.7 points over the decade — by rank, one of the country's poorest showings on any indicator, and an odd result for a state whose service digitisation is otherwise well regarded.

The barriers between a service existing and a person obtaining it are ordinary ones. The national identity card carries a fee, with exemptions for young children and for over-60s without income (2024), and its digital functions require a smart-card reader, dedicated middleware and a PIN letter obtained from the issuing service — a chain that puts the digital credential further out of reach than the card it sits on. Against that, the design does carry registration to people who cannot travel to it: the civil-registry conservatórias act as collection points, with mobile registration units serving citizens unable to reach them, and Casa do Cidadão one-stop shops keep a counter and a contact centre alongside the web channel (2025), so digitisation has not yet been allowed to become digital-only.

Some people sit outside the frame altogether. Civil registration reaches citizens and permanent residents only: there is no refugee or asylum status determination mechanism and asylum seekers are not systematically registered (2023), and foreign residents are handled through a residence permit, to which the mobile key can be attached (2024). Nor does the register that gates social benefits yet reach the whole resident population (2023). The state's own account of the front end is more confident: it reports its citizen feedback platforms as supporting users with disabilities, including voice commands (2025). Finance has no such provision: the central bank said in July 2026 that the financial system has no specific rule on the accessibility of digital financial services for blind and low-vision people.

Digital divides

The line that matters in Cabo Verde no longer runs between the connected and the unconnected: a usage divide persists between the level of access the country has reached and what its population can actually do with it (2025), which is a harder problem for an archipelago than laying more capacity.

Where the remaining gap falls is devices and income rather than the connection itself. The statistics institute's 2025 survey found 69.3 per cent of rural households and 68.5 per cent of urban ones with internet at home, but a computer in 34.6 per cent of urban households against 14.3 per cent of rural ones, with 77.3 per cent of people aged

10 and over online in the previous three months. Afrobarometer survey work finds rural and lower-income households less likely than urban ones to have reliable devices and internet access, a shortfall that constrains remote and e-learning provision even where the school's own administrative systems are fully digitised. The distributional measures have moved against the infrastructure ones: over the decade to 2023 the country's internet and computers score rose sharply while its equality in education score fell to its weakest rank of any education indicator. Connectivity itself has stopped doing the work: through 2025 the mobile subscriber base grew while the internet subscriber base contracted. Public access points fill part of the gap: state-supported internet is available through digital squares in all 22 municipalities, 24 hours a day, and a 2024 decree-law made the squares eligible for free broadband under the Programa Conectar Cabo Verde.

The policy answer is framed almost entirely as skills. A national digital-skills strategy sits under the Digital Cabo Verde programme with the World Bank (August 2025), free digital-skills programmes for citizens and schools are reported (2025), and Skodji Digital trains young Cabo Verdeans for remote and digitally delivered work (February 2026). The domestic argument has already moved past that: the national press debates whether artificial intelligence widens the gap between rich and poor countries, and whether a country without its own data can train its own algorithms (May 2025).

Data

National statistics

Cabo Verde's IV IDRF household income and expenditure survey, fielded from December 2022, still had no definitive results more than three years later, so in July 2026 the World Bank microsimulated its poverty estimate from the III IDRF of 2015 — and the headline poverty rate turns on which international line is applied rather than on any new measurement.

The money moves no faster. The Sistema de Informação para o Desenvolvimento Sustentável programme, the budget line funding the statistical system, executed 9.8% of its reprogrammed FY2024 budget — a budget raised in-year from CVE 788,167,895 to CVE 4,974,474,263, 92.8% of it borrowed. Of the CVE 253,112,171 the Treasury put in, 96.2% was drawn: the state spent almost all its own money on statistics and almost none of what it borrowed.

Against a state-wide execution rate of 76.5% in FY2024 that is the worst of three digital-adjacent programmes: the digital platform programme managed 43.2%, state modernisation 54.7%.

The count itself is uneven. As at 2023 population, agricultural and economic censuses had been held within ten years and labour force and business surveys three or more times each, but there had been no agricultural survey and no health survey in that decade, and only one household survey. The sixth General Agricultural Census, launched in July 2025, is meant to seed a permanent system of integrated agricultural surveys. Capacity of the statistical system is Cabo Verde's weakest public administration measure by rank, 58.2 of 100 and 17th of 54 African states in 2023.

The National Statistics Council opened work on a first National Data Strategy in April 2025, noting how fragmented administrative data remains across government. INE's independence went before Parliament in late July 2026, where the Prime Minister said public data belong to no government but to all citizens and that national statistics cannot serve as propaganda, and announced an independent evaluation of INE; INE's board offered to host any external mission or peer review and to open its technical documentation.

Open data

What the Cabo Verdean state publishes of its own motion has gone backwards even as access to records improved: disclosure of public records fell 12.5 points over 2014-2023 to 45.8 of 100, 12th of 54 African states and among the country's ten most deteriorated governance indicators, while accessibility of public records rose 22.5 points, its third largest ten-year gain, though at 42.0 of 100 it is still among its ten worst measures.

The right of access is in place and has a name: Lei 10/X/2022, gazetted on 16 May 2022, regulates access to and re-use of administrative documents and administrative information held by the bodies and entities listed in its article 2, and as at 2025 the legislation was recorded as effective, with an entity monitoring implementation and compliance, and e-procurement data is published to the Open Contracting Data Standard. Missing is any account of the state's own performance: government publishes neither the data protection authority's results nor progress on the right-to-information law, including how many requests are received and granted, nor public service delivery performance nor the public investment project database, nor the progress reports of its govtech and data governance institutions, which exist internally only.

Published coverage is concentrated in economic and demographic series. Labour (7.5 of 10) and population (7.0) score best in ODIN 2024, followed by balance of payments, trade, money and banking and national accounts at 6.5 each; government finance sits at 4.5, with crime and gender statistics at 4.0 each; and education facilities is the weakest at 2.0, with energy, natural resources and food security at 3.0.

On the public accounts, the finance ministry's published series of Contas Gerais do Estado runs 2005 to 2024, the 2024 account appearing on 30 September 2025, so the finest published record of state spending for 2025 and 2026 is the provisional quarterly account, an executive self-report, not an audited figure.

An open-data portal has been promised repeatedly: among the 2024 deliverables named under the AEMEAP administrative modernisation strategy, a commitment in the 2023-2025 Open Government Partnership action plan, and part of what an African Development Bank programme of 2024-2025 funds, alongside a transparency portal put to public consultation in 2025. By 2025 government reported a portal carrying a comprehensive catalogue, updated on annual, quarterly and monthly cycles.

Use of satellite data

Government use of Earth-observation data rests on two institutions and no programme. A geospatial laboratory opened with the national agrarian research institute on Santiago in March 2022 is building a water and food security monitoring system on near-real-time satellite observations, on the partner university's account, and the meteorology institute holds the national meteorological watch, forecasting and warnings, under an early-warnings-for-all roll-out launched in December 2025. No national instrument or agreement naming an Earth-observation data source or programme is on the record as at September 2026.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

The United States' one financing instrument for Cabo Verde has lapsed: the third Millennium Challenge compact, whose initial agreement was signed in April 2024, was officially terminated in December 2025, and the country is on the FY2027 eligible list without having said whether it will apply (September 2026). What remains is a satellite operator that arrived ahead of the rules: Starlink went live in December 2024, and a dedicated framework for satellite services went to public consultation only in August 2026. The Prime Minister had told the 2025 budget debate a month before go-live that the service was already in the national market and expected it to change

competition in telecoms. It has not, so far. On the regulator ARME's own quarterly series, Starlink held 0.64 per cent of internet subscriptions at the end of March 2026. What the position gives its operator is a channel outside the incumbent's network rather than a share of the market.

The compact had been put to the same budget debate as a selection, directed at connectivity in transport, services and digital links with the African continent. The one American commitment on the record that reaches the state's own systems is commercial: the cabinet authorised in June 2025 the finance ministry's spending on the state's accession to Microsoft's Digital Development Program through NOSi, a partnership running since 2005 whose scope includes the government cloud. Otherwise the equipment layer of the e-government estate was financed elsewhere, and the identity credential is now printed at home.

China activities

Five Chinese-financed commitments to Cabo Verde's digital estate are on the record: four agreed between 2016 and 2019, all closed, and a Ministry of Commerce grant for the third phase of the Safe City project in 2026. Together, four from China's Ministry of Commerce and one from China Eximbank, they come to about USD 48 million as at September 2026, behind the African Development Bank's six worth about USD 131 million, the World Bank's five worth about USD 89 million and the European Investment Bank's two worth about USD 65 million.

Closed commitments are not closed dependencies. China Eximbank's RMB 84.5 million concessional loan, signed on 20 February 2017 for Phase 2 of the E-Governance Project, fully financed a commercial contract with Huawei Technologies concluded in September 2015, at 2% interest on a twenty-year maturity with a seven-year grace period — the repayment schedule outlasts the equipment it bought. A companion Chinese grant under the same programme upgraded networks in schools, public institutions and hospitals and supplied the computing and storage the state's e-government system runs on. A Ministry of Commerce grant laid 16 km of fibre and installed LAN, WiFi and equipment for public institutions on the State Private Technological Network, was extended in May 2018 to reach health services and 23 schools on Santiago, and was handed to the government on 29 January 2020.

The same relationship built the surveillance layer. China funded Phase 2 of the Safe City project by exchange of notes in May 2019, with Huawei Technologies as equipment supplier and implementing contractor, extending Praia's video surveillance network and putting camera poles on São Vicente, Sal and Boa Vista, each carrying three cameras, together with a 4G LTE network for police communications. A third phase followed in August 2026: China made about EUR 9.3m available in non-reimbursable assistance, the implementation agreement signed in the week to 15 August 2026 by the interior minister and the Chinese ambassador at the National Police Command Centre in Praia, and it covers command centres, data centres and wireless base stations at Assomada, Tarrafal de Santiago and Porto Novo, reinforcement of existing capacity in Praia and Mindelo, and a wider video-surveillance network, stated as reinforcing the technological and operational capacity of the security forces and supporting criminal investigation.

Regionally, the footprint is newer. The China-aid ECOWAS Headquarters building was handed over in Abuja on 28 April 2026, the seat of the Commission that administers the regional instruments binding Cabo Verde.

EU activities

Cabo Verde's identity card, electronic passport and residence title for foreigners, produced and personalised under contract by Portugal's Imprensa Nacional Casa da Moeda as recently as July 2025, have been printed at home since 18 May 2026, on a national security press equipped through the EU-funded GESTDOC project with Portugal's Casa da Moeda as technical partner.

European money holds the wire too. European Investment Bank lending finances a branch off a new submarine cable linking Europe to South Africa into Cabo Verde's national network, urgent modernisation of the national transmission network, and an upgrade of Cabo Verde Telecom's information systems (2024); an earlier EIB loan to the same operator had already funded the country's connection to international submarine cable systems and broadband improvements between 2019 and 2022. That is the incumbent's international capacity and its back-office systems, financed from one source.

The European Investment Bank is Cabo Verde's third-largest non-state digital financier on the record as at September 2026, with two commitments worth about USD 65 million, behind the African Development Bank's six worth about USD 131 million and the World Bank's five worth about USD 89 million.

Above the finance sits a bilateral frame that has been growing digital limbs. The EU–Cabo Verde special partnership was described in the 2024 budget debate as gaining a digital-transformation pillar and a cybersecurity strand (November 2023), and a year later the Prime Minister put a EUR 300 million EU Global Gateway package to the 2025 budget debate. The reach now runs into policy drafting: Cabo Verde kicked off a data strategy for public administration and a national artificial intelligence strategy with European Union representatives at the table, by May 2026, aimed at integrating government data across departments. In the private layer, the Portuguese cybersecurity firm VisionWare was among the first companies into both of Cabo Verde's TechParks and recruits its local staff through the NOSi Akademia training pipeline (May 2025).

The 14th special partnership ministerial in Brussels on 9 October 2026 reported a Global Gateway digital pipeline in preparation, covering submarine cables and inter-island connectivity, and progress in European support for the national data and AI strategies.

Gulf/UAE activities

The only Gulf engagement on the record is a declared wish: at Web Summit Qatar on 3 February 2026 the Secretary of State for the Digital Economy stated the country's wish to strengthen cooperation with Qatar at governmental and private-sector level. No memorandum, financing commitment or project with any Gulf state or company is on the record as at September 2026.

India activities

India's engagement of record is a single project, and it is fifteen years old. The Pan-African e-Network was inaugurated in Praia on 29 July 2010, implemented by the Indian company TCIL with NOSi and financed by the Government of India, connecting Cabo Verdean institutions over fibre and satellite to a TCIL data centre and studio in New Delhi, to twelve Indian hospitals and seven Indian universities, and to five regional African universities and five hospitals, for tele-education, telemedicine, heads-of-state videoconferencing, internet access, e-government and e-commerce. Nothing on the record reports its operation, its closure or any later Indian line of credit, technical-cooperation record or forum commitment naming Cabo Verde.

Digital sovereignty

Cabo Verde has put a price on printing its own identity documents: the national printer puts the cost at an estimated CVE 400–500 million, more than CVE 300 million of it its own spending on premises and about CVE 140 million from the EU-funded GESTDOC project, and is seeking ECOWAS and CPLP customers for capacity well beyond national demand (June 2026).

Control of the core systems is written into instruments. Decreto-Lei 47/2022 makes a prior opinion compulsory before any central-administration purchase of ICT goods or services and requires digital initiatives to align with the state's Autentika identity and PDEX exchange platforms; Resolução 46/2025 requires NOSi to give every public-

administration information system interfaces to the Portal Único, and gives the government's digital service team the power to make the interoperability framework mandatory. The state data centre at Achada Grande was declared critical infrastructure in September 2015, at NOSi's request.

The exceptions are the facilities others finance or run. The Technology Park's second government data centre is to be managed under a public-private concession, and the third phase of the Chinese-financed Safe City project adds command centres and data centres at Assomada, Tarrafal de Santiago and Porto Novo (August 2026). The terms on which the Technology Park data-centre concession and the Safe City agreements govern data jurisdiction, portability and exit had not been published as at September 2026.

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